

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1982-07-19

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

the misunderstandings which still exist concerning the registration of Bahá'í children and youth, and it has instructed us to send you the following clarifications.

333.2 The beloved Guardian's secretary wrote on his behalf to your National Spiritual Assembly on 17 June 1954:

333.2a Although the children of Bahá'í parents are considered to be Bahá'ís, there is no objection at the present time, for purposes of keeping a correct census, and also ascertaining whether the young people are, sincerely, believers, and willing to do their share in service to the Faith, to asking them to make a declaration of their intention, at the age of fifteen or so. Originally the Guardian understands this was adopted in America to enable young Bahá'í men to make certain arrangements in connection with their application for noncombatant status, upon their attaining the age of military service. There is really nothing about it in the Teachings or in the Administration. Your Assembly is free to do as it pleases in this matter. 333.2b He has also written that in deciding who is to be regarded as a believer, Assemblies must refrain as far as possible from drawing rigidly the line of demarcation.

333.3 At the present time, with so many more young people entering the Faith, and with such a great increase in mobility from country to country, the House of Justice feels that it is necessary to establish certain guidelines which will apply to all National Spiritual Assemblies in this delicate issue, while matters of procedure are left to each National Assembly to decide according to the conditions in its own area of jurisdiction. In the current phase of the Seven Year Plan, for example, the House of Justice has called on Assemblies to keep registers of the birth of Bahá'í children, and great stress is being laid on the Bahá'í education of children and on the activities of Bahá'í youth.

333.4 In letters replying to questions on the registration of children and youth the Universal House of Justice has attempted to avoid laying down rulings that are universally applicable. However, for the assistance of National Spiritual Assemblies it is now providing the following summary of guidelines and elucidations that have been given. We are to emphasize that no hard and fast lines should be drawn, and procedural matters must never be allowed to eclipse the spiritual reality of belief, which is an intensely personal relationship between the soul and its Creator. Bahá'í Children 333.5 Unlike the children of some other religions, Bahá'í children do not automatically inherit the Faith of their parents. However, the parents are responsible for the upbringing and spiritual welfare of their children, and Spiritual Assemblies have the duty to assist parents, if necessary, in fulfilling these obligations, so that the children will be reared in the light of the Revelation of 437Bahá'u'lláh and from their earliest years will learn to love God and His Manifestations and to walk in the way of God's Law. It is natural, therefore, to regard the children of Bahá'ís as Bahá'ís unless there is a reason to conclude the contrary. It is quite wrong to think of Bahá'í children as existing in some sort of spiritual limbo until the age of fifteen at which point they can "become" Bahá'ís. In the light of this one can conclude the following:

333.6 Children born to a Bahá'í couple are regarded as Bahá'ís from the beginning of their lives, and their births should be registered by the Spiritual Assembly.

333.7 The birth of a child to a couple, one of whom is a Bahá'í, should also be registered unless the non-Bahá'í parent objects.

333.8 A Spiritual Assembly may accept the declaration of faith of a child of non-Bahá'í parents, and register him as a Bahá'í child, provided the parents give their consent. 333.9 In the cases of children whose parents become Bahá'ís, much depends upon the ages and reactions of the children concerned. They will require great love and understanding, and each case must be judged on its own merits. This applies to an added degree, of course, if only one of the parents has accepted the Faith, in which case the attitude of the other parent is an important factor; the aim of the Bahá'ís should be to foster family unity. The important thing is that the children, whether registered as Bahá'ís or not, should be made to feel welcome at Bahá'í children's classes and other community gatherings.

333.10 It is within a Spiritual Assembly's discretion to request Bahá'í children to undertake work of which they are capable in service to the Faith, such as service on suitable committees. Bahá'í Youth 333.11 Fifteen is the age at which a child attains spiritual maturity, and thus it is at the age of fifteen that a Bahá'í child assumes the responsibility for obeying such laws as those of fasting and prayer, and for affirming of his own volition his faith in Bahá'u'lláh.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]